heart forgave Salim for this crime. Salim had, on the other hand, pragmatically if somewhat cynically believed that ‘although this caused distress to (Akbar), in the end it resulted in my being able to proceed to kiss the threshold of my exalted father’s court without fear, and little by little the bad blood between us subsided’.

These were sorely disappointing times for Akbar, for now news reached the court that Daniyal, who on his father’s insistence ‘had for a time given up wine-drinking, and had broken his wine-vessels, and had taken an oath against drinking wine’, had once again descended into abject alcoholism in the Deccan. He sent recommendations and strong instructions to the prince through Abdur Rahim, that he should desist from alcohol, and urged him to remember the tragic fate of his brother Murad. But Daniyal seemed to find it easier to be seduced by the temptations that his companions were only too willing to offer to him, now that they were far from the stern gaze of his father, the Padshah. Instead, in an example of princely equivocation, Daniyal sent his father as peshkash a 15-carat diamond and a 120-carat ruby.

The members of the harem were devastated by news of the assassination of Abu’l Fazl and terribly anxious over the fate of their favourite prince, Salim. They realized that a sacred line had been breached and that the Padshah had been deeply wounded by this cowardly blow. Hamida Banu and Gulbadan now appeared before Akbar to plead for forgiveness on behalf of the prince. Akbar finally relented, never able to refuse these two ladies. He ordered that Salima Sultan Begum be sent to Allahabad to convince the prince of his father’s forgiveness and to bring him to court. Taking one of Akbar’s elephants, Fath Lashkar, a special horse, and a robe of honour, Salima Sultan set off to bring back the prodigal son.

As for Gulbadan, at the age of eighty-two, she had carried out her very last duty to the Timurid line with grace and dignity, as she had done her whole life. Gulbadan had led a turbulent, exciting and unfettered life. She had lived a life surprisingly without constraints, true to her family, and her God. As she lay in her room, her old companion-in-arms, Hamida Banu, stood over her, trying to revive her friend, repeatedly calling out to her in terms of endearment, ‘Begum Jio!’ Gulbadan opened her eyes one last time to say to the weeping Hamida Banu, ‘I am dying, may you live long’, before dying on 7 February 1603.